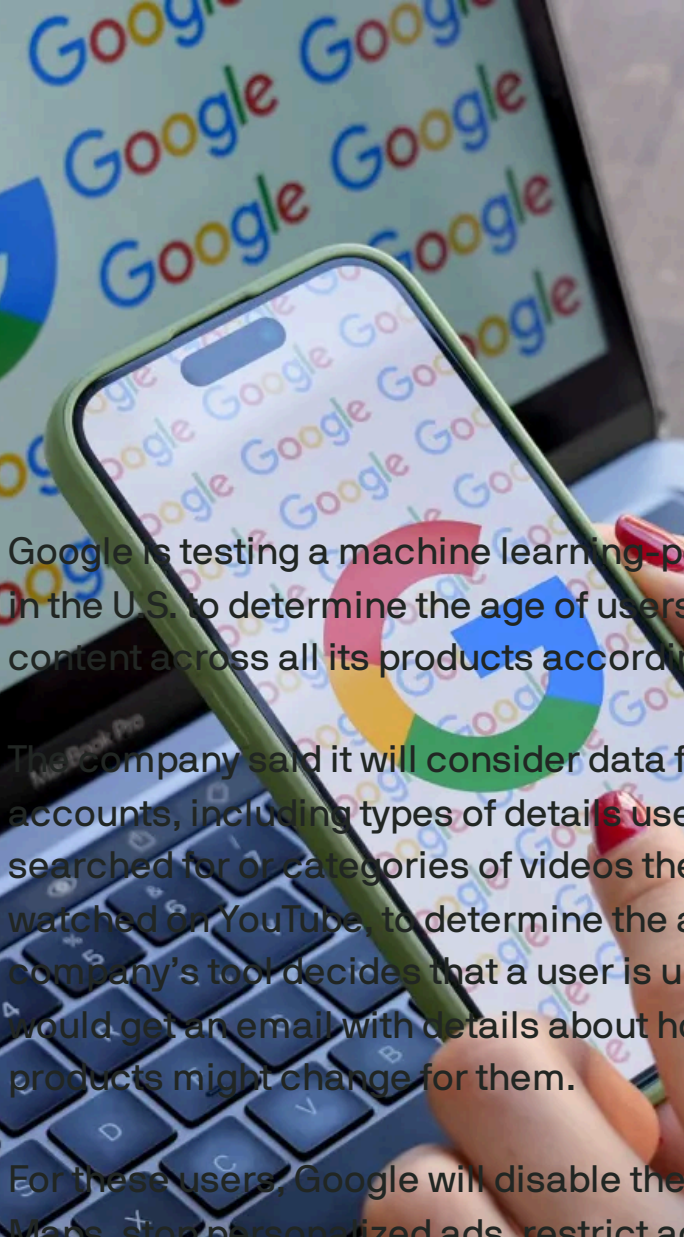


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Google is experimenting
with machine learning-
powered age-estimation
tech in the US



Google is testing a machine learning-powered tech in the U.S. to determine the age of users and filter content across all its products accordingly.

The company said it will consider data from Google accounts, including types of details users have searched for or categories of videos they have watched on YouTube, to determine the age. If the company's tool decides that a user is under 18, they would get an email with details about how Google products might change for them.

For these users, Google will disable the timeline in Maps, stop personalized ads, restrict age-restricted ad categories, and bar them from accessing adult-themed apps on the Play Store. The company will also turn on [digital well-being features](#) on YouTube, such as break reminders and “go to bed” notifications when consuming videos late at night. Plus, it will prevent underage users from accessing certain kinds of content — [such as content that could trigger body image issues](#) — repeatedly.

If users think they have been tagged as an underage account by mistake, they can appeal the decision and prove their age using a photo of their government ID or a selfie.

Google rolled out [similar measures for YouTube earlier this week](#), and now the company is experimenting with machine learning-based age

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gating in the U.S. for Google accounts at large. The company said that it has experimented with age-estimation tech in some markets (without specifying which ones), and it worked well.

“Age assurance helps us ensure that adults can access the information and services they need, while also applying the right protections for our younger users. Our approach to age assurance uses a combination of age estimation and, when necessary, age verification,” Google [said in a post](#).

Other platforms, [including](#) Instagram and [Roblox](#), have also started using AI to estimate the age of their users. Lawmakers have been at work to put in rules related to serving appropriate content to minors. In the U.S., several states have existing or proposed laws around age gating. Meanwhile, platforms have also [started age verification](#) in the U.K. following the passing of [the Online Safety Act](#).

Topics: [age verification](#) [AI](#) [Google](#) [Privacy](#)

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APPS



Google expands Family Link parental controls with screen time tools, approved contacts, and more

Sarah Perez — 11:00 AM PST · February 12, 2025

Google on Wednesday [announced](#) a series of updates for its parental control software [Google Family Link](#) and a plan to test new machine-learning techniques to estimate users' ages so it could apply more age-appropriate experiences to kids' devices.

The company earlier said that it would soon use [machine learning to determine the age of YouTube users](#) for better recommendations, but Google tells TechCrunch it will also test this feature at the Google account level. That means it will be applicable across Google products, including but not limited to YouTube.

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Those tests of the age estimation model will begin in the U.S. sometime this year and will expand to more countries over time. Other social media services like [Facebook](#), [Instagram](#), and [TikTok](#) already use age estimation and verification technologies.

Meanwhile, Google’s Family Link parental control software is also gaining a few improvements. The app is designed to allow parents or guardians to restrict kids’ access to content and control various privacy and security settings across a range of services, including Google Search, Photos, Assistant, YouTube, Chrome, and more.

Now Family Link is being updated to include tools for managing kids’ screen time across their Android and Chrome devices while also helping kids stay focused at school.

A new feature called School Time will begin to roll out next week to Android phones and tablets, letting parents “automatically limit or adjust” the child’s device during certain hours, as well as restrict access to certain apps.

Later, parents will also be able to add contacts to their child’s device and then set controls to restrict the child to only being able to call or text those approved contacts. This could be useful when giving phones to younger kids who may need to be able to call Mom or Dad or grandparents, but not others.

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Google says this addition will start to roll out in March.

Kids with Android devices will be able to pay in-store using Google Wallet sometime later this spring, too. Google says parents of supervised Android users under the age of consent will be able to add a payment card to their child's Google Wallet so the kids can use tap and pay. Parents will also be able to approve new cards, remove cards, add gift cards and tickets to their child's wallet, and see the child's transaction history.

Teens will be able to access more AI-powered features later this year, including a "[Learn About](#)" generative AI-powered tool that offers interactive learning experiences and the AI research assistant [NotebookLM](#). These join the AI features already offers to teens, like AI Overviews in Google Search, AI chatbot Gemini, and Circle to Search.

Under the threat of stricter regulations in the U.S. and abroad, Google and other tech giants started introducing additional safeguards and privacy features for minors. In Google's case, it began defaulting under-18 users to its SafeSearch Filter, restricted sensitive ads, age-gated content on YouTube, and more.

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Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having...

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APPS



Instagram expands AI-powered age verification program to India and Brazil

Ivan Mehta — 11:11 PM PDT · October 13, 2022

Instagram, facing scrutiny from safety advocates, started testing a program in the U.S. earlier this year to verify users' age of those claiming to be 18 or older. It uses techniques including authentication via [running video selfies through an artificial intelligence system](#). The Meta-owned service is now ready to roll out this program to two key overseas markets: India and Brazil.

These countries together have about 400 million monthly active users on Instagram, according to market intelligence platform Sensor Tower, data of which an industry executive shared with TechCrunch. The social network said in an [updated](#)

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[blog post](#) that it plans to roll out this age verification program to the U.K. and EU before the end of the year.

Users can verify their age by providing an ID. Instagram has [a list of documents it accepts for verification](#).

The program allows users to upload a video of themselves, which Instagram runs through an AI system to determine whether they are indeed aged 18 or older. For this option, Instagram has partnered with the U.K.-based identity startup Yoti. Once users complete taking a video selfie by following the on-screen instructions, Meta shares that with Yoti for verification through its specially trained AI. Both companies say they delete the data afterward.

Many social media companies use [Yoti's age estimation tech](#) for verification as many users might not have a valid ID that is accepted by Instagram.

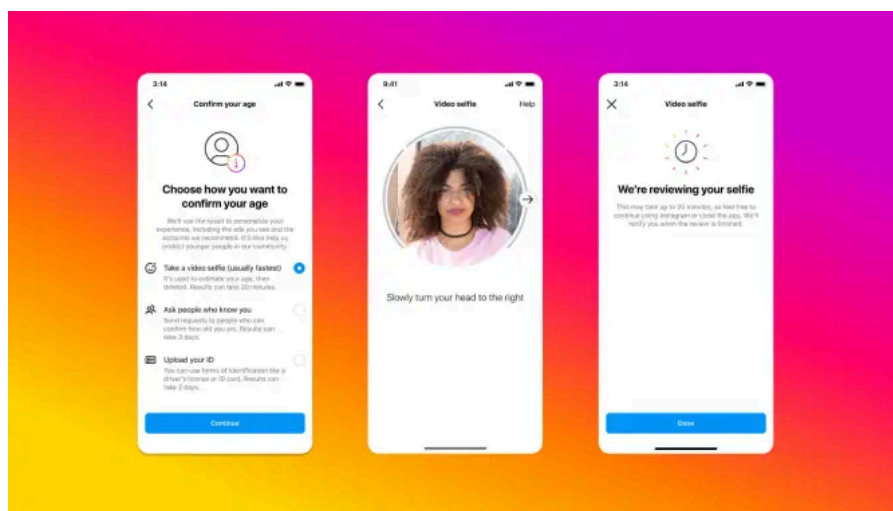
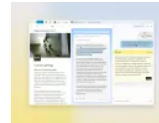


IMAGE CREDITS: INSTAGRAM

The social giant also said it is removing Social Vouching as an option to verify age. Social Vouching, one of the experimental ways Instagram verified the age as part of the new program, allowed a user to request their mutual followers, who are aged 18 or above, to vouch for the age. While it didn't expand on the reason, it is likely that some users were gaming the system by asking

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Ivan Mehta - 18 minutes ago

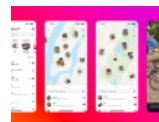
AI



Google takes on ChatGPT's Study Mode with new 'Guided Learning' tool in Gemini

Aisha Malik - 12 hours ago

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Instagram takes on Snapchat with new 'Instagram Map'

Aisha Malik - 17 hours ago

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their mutual followers aged 18 or above to lie for them.

The rollout comes at a time when safety advocates are lambasting Instagram for letting kids under 13 use the platform and not doing enough to stop teens from potentially seeing harmful content. On its part, last year Instagram made it [mandatory for everyone to enter their birthdates](#), but it's hard to rely only on that factor as users can easily provide false information. Notably, Twitter is rolling out a feature that [asks users to enter their birthdates to see sensitive content](#).

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Instagram says it uses age data to restrict certain experiences for teens: it makes accounts of users under 16 private by default, blocks DMs from unknown adults and stops advertisers to serve targeted ads based on teens' interests and activities.

Lawmakers across the world are also looking at introducing rules that force platforms to have effective age checks in place. [The U.K.'s Online Safety Bill](#) and the [California Age-Appropriate Design Code Act](#) look to restrict content that users aged under 18 can access. Their scrutiny was partially prompted after a whistleblower testified last year to reveal that Facebook had prioritized profit over the well-being of users, especially teens.

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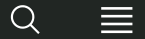
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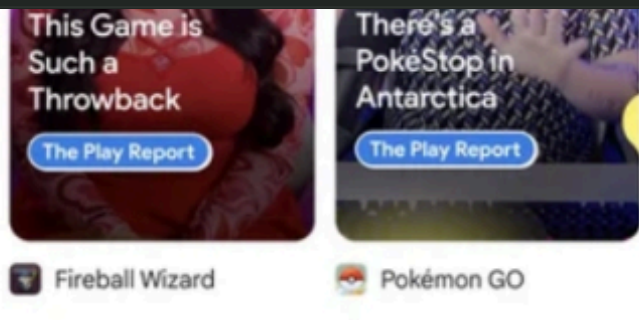


IMAGE CREDITS: GOOGLE

Ivan Mehta — 5:16 AM PDT · September 6, 2023

If you think almost every app has some form of vertical video, add one more unexpected one to the list: Google Play Store. Google has introduced [an original video series](#) called “The Play Report” to let people discover new apps, and it will show up in the Play Store as well.

The company said it will start showing these videos on the Play Store home page to select users in the U.S. Other users will be able to watch these videos on Google Play’s [YouTube](#), [Facebook](#) and [Instagram](#) accounts.

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Design agents are here — Lovart launches the first end-to-end AI canvas for design

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While the company didn't mention this tidbit explicitly, a GIF posted on its blog post suggests these videos are YouTube Shorts. Apart from the video, users will see a handy install icon for the app that's being talked about in the video.

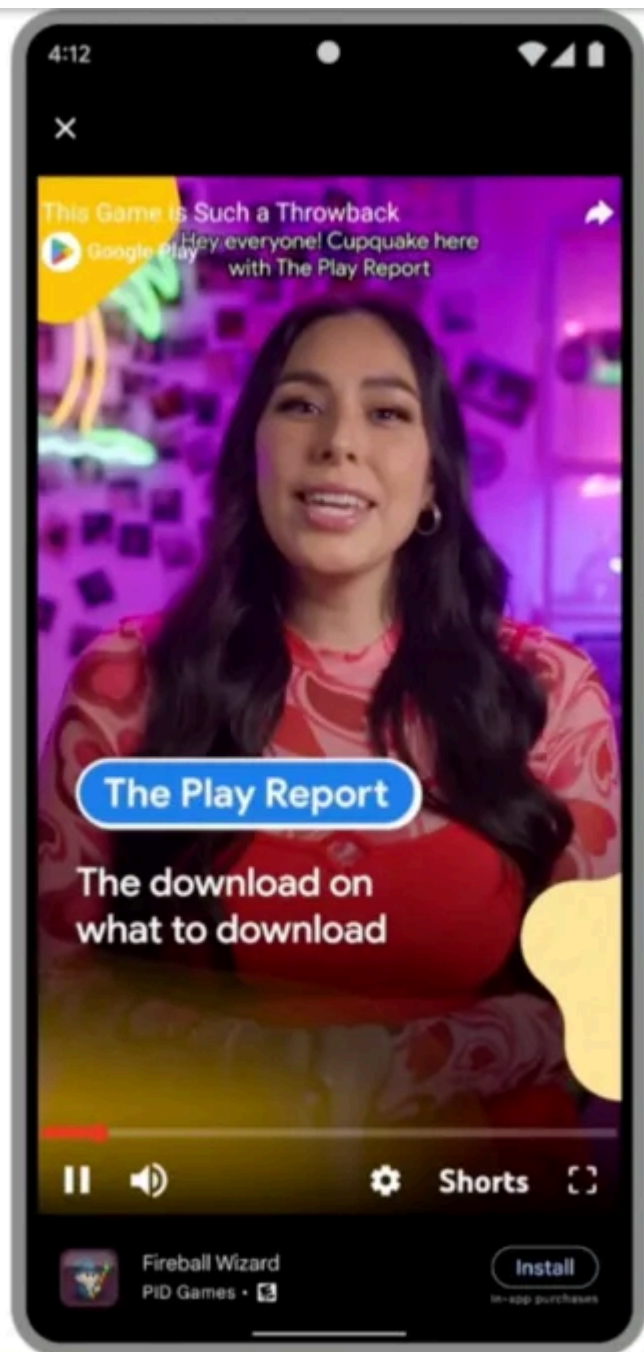


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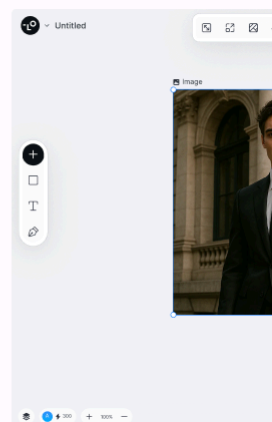
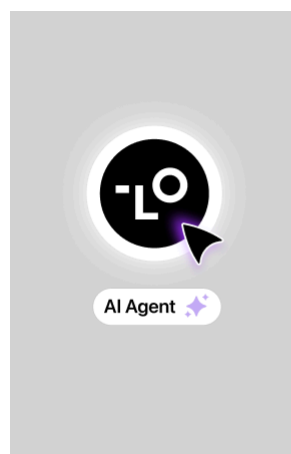
Google said each episode will feature experts, creators and even Google employees highlighting different apps.

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Importantly, the Play Store already lets developers link YouTube videos as part of their app's media assets, which appears on the app's listing page. It's not clear if Google will expand the short video support on Play Store to other creators or developers beyond this program. The Android maker also didn't mention if the apps featured are picked by the company or the creators themselves.

Google has already benefited a lot from Shorts. In July, during its Q3 2023 earnings call, the company said more than [2 billion logged-in monthly users are watching Shorts](#). The Play Store is another surface for Google to utilize the short video format to aid app discovery.

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APPS





Google is working on cross-device notifications to let you resume media playback on the move

Ivan Mehta — 10:00 AM PST · January 5, 2023

Google hasn't had a massive presence at this year's [Consumer Electronics Show \(CES\)](#). But the search giant announced that it is working on a couple of useful media playback features including better playback options for [Spotify Connect](#)-compatible devices and cross-device notifications to let you resume media playback on the move.

IMAGE CREDITS:

AELINA KURLANOVA / GETTY IMAGES

The idea behind cross-device notifications is that you can start playing a playlist or a podcast in your car and resume the playback on your phone or TV. Currently, Google is working on supporting YouTube Music and Spotify for this cross-device playback system.

The company said it uses a combination of signals such as Bluetooth Low Energy, Wi-Fi and ultra-wideband (UWB), along with the nearby device feature that identifies the proximity of devices. These things enable experiences like showing a notification to resume playback on your phone when you leave your car.

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What's more, Google is also working on making it easier to switch playback devices while using Spotify. Just like Google's Chromecast built-in and [Apple's AirPlay](#), Spotify Connect is a standard that lets you "cast" media playing on Spotify to compatible speakers such as [an Amazon Echo](#).

Currently, users have to use the Spotify app to use Spotify Connect and switch between compatible speakers. But soon they can use Android 13's revamped media switcher to shuffle between speakers.

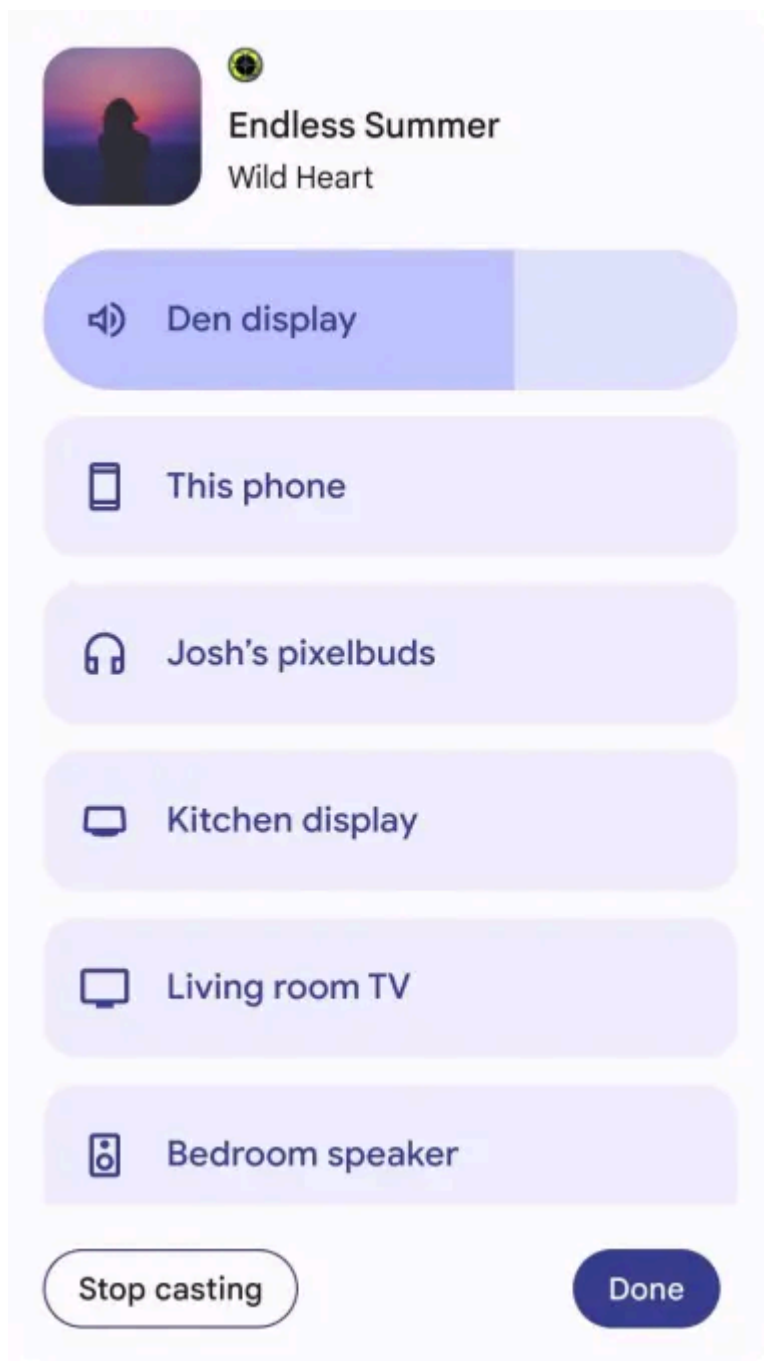


IMAGE CREDITS: GOOGLE

Google didn't specify when these features will be available to users across the globe.

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While these are minor enhancements, it's obvious that Google wants to play nice with Spotify, which has been super critical of Apple. Last year, Google struck a deal with Spotify to make the music streaming service [the first partner for its third-party billing services pilot on the Play Store](#). Now the search company is making Spotify users' lives easier on its own ecosystem with these enhancements.

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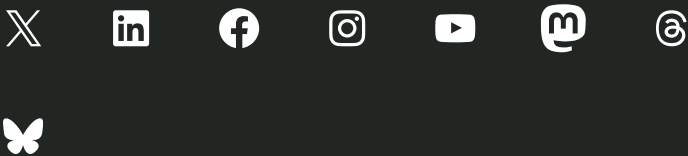
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